

FRIDAY NIGHT DYNASTY 2026 — DEEP DIVE #1

Create Your World: Leagues, Customization & Team Profiles

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Welcome to the first of a series of Deep Dives into Friday Night Dynasty 2026! A browser-based high school football simulation that puts you in the place of head coach. You get to control all aspects of the program — from the equipment you buy to how you develop players in the offseason. Full control that was developed from coaches with nearly 100+ combined years of high school football experience.

This first deep dive was important to us because while we have a fantastic fictional world ready to play, many coaches want to create their own world they can dive into. That may be a fully fictional league you design from scratch, or a real state you want to experience — your hometown, your rivals, your classification battles.

FND 26 is built to support both. Here's how the world-building layer works.

WHY YOUR LEAGUE SETUP MATTERS

Everything in a dynasty flows from the league file. Who you play, how playoffs work, how big rosters are, what kind of kids come through your middle school pipeline — it all starts with how you structure and customize your save.

You are not just picking a team. You are defining a football ecosystem.

LEAGUE SETUP

TEAM COUNT: THE 100–150 SWEET SPOT

Most leagues are designed to run between 100 and 150 teams. Keep your total in an even number when possible — it helps regional splits and scheduling templates balance cleanly.

Common layouts:

32 teams in one class (4 regions × 8 schools)

40 teams in one class (4 regions × 10 schools)
80 teams across two classes (40 per class)
120 teams across three classes (40 per class)
128 teams across four classes (32 per class)

Smaller states can include every school in the state. Bigger states may need to focus on one or two classifications to keep the save stable and performant. There is no hard cap at exactly 150, but staying in that range keeps seasons simulating smoothly while still feeling like a full statewide picture.

REGIONS & CONFERENCES

Many states organize football by region, conference, or district. FND uses a region field on each team to power scheduling.

Teams with the same classification AND region form a scheduling pod. They play each other in the regular season (round-robin). Region names are free-form — use whatever matches your state:

Compass style: North, East, South, West
Letter pods: A, B, C, D
Numbered: Region 1, Region 2, Region 3, Region 4
Or your own: Metro, Valley, Coastal, Mountain — whatever fits

At the end of the regular season, the best record in each pod earns a regional title (tracked on your Team Profile as regional championships). That matters for history, pride, and the story of your program — even before playoffs begin.

CLASSIFICATIONS & DIVISIONS

Each team carries a classification (1A, 2A, 3A, 4A, 5A, 6A, or your own labels). Classifications can coexist in one save:

A small-state save might run 1A through 4A with 30–40 teams per class.
A large-state save might run only 5A and 6A to capture the biggest schools.
A fictional save might invent "Gold" and "Silver" divisions — the engine keys off the classification string, not the name itself.

Enrollment on each school helps drive classification and roster size (see Team Profile below). When building a custom JSON league, keep total teams close to the 100–150 target and try to keep regions within a class evenly sized.

THE REGULAR SEASON SCHEDULE

The default model is a regional schedule plus non-region games:

IN-REGION: Teams in your pod play a round-robin against each other. Pod size determines how many in-region weeks you get (typically 7–9 games).

CROSS-REGION: Additional games are played against schools outside your pod. In many league templates, the head coach picks these opponents in the preseason — choosing who you play and whether you're home or away.

Common league templates FND recognizes:

- 2×10 — 2 regions of 10 teams; 9 in-region games + 1 cross-region pick
- 4×10 — 4 regions of 10 teams; 9 in-region + 1 cross-region
- 4×8 — 4 regions of 8 teams; 7 in-region + 3 cross-region picks
- 4×7 — 4 regions of 7 teams; 7 in-region + 4 cross-region picks

Some classes (like a pod-only 3A league) skip cross-region picking entirely — every game is in-region. The schedule planning screen tells you exactly what your class requires.

Cross-region picks are strategic: schedule a powerhouse to test your team, or schedule a weaker opponent to protect your record and program momentum. Those choices feed into Culture, Facilities, and Booster progression throughout the season.

PLAYOFF SETUPS

Playoff structure is declared in your league JSON via a `playoff_system` id. FND ships several templates, and more can be added over time:

- wv (default)
 - 8-team bracket per classification
 - Seeded 1–8 by wins, then point differential
 - One state champion per class

- wv16
 - 16-team bracket per classification
 - Same seeding logic, larger field

- regional_4x4
 - 16 teams per class (4 regions × top 4 from each)

- Regional semifinals and finals, then state semis and championship
- Most common "regional playoff" feel in real high school football

regional_8x4

- 32 teams per class (4 regions × top 8)
- Deeper regional rounds before state semifinals

Playoff systems can also be restructured as the project grows — the league JSON references a system id, and the engine handles bracket generation, seeding, and round names from that config.

Key distinction:

- PER-CLASSIFICATION — each class (1A, 2A, etc.) crowns its own state champion
- STATE-WIDE — one bracket across all teams (supported in the system architecture)

Most real-world leagues use per-classification brackets. Regional seeding modes split qualifiers by region before state semifinals — mirroring how many states actually run postseason football.

BUILDING A CUSTOM LEAGUE (JSON)

To create your own world:

1. Start from a league JSON file (download from the community / Discord, or export from an existing template).
2. On the New Dynasty screen, choose "Upload .json" as your team dataset.
3. Pick your school, build your coach, and create the save.
4. In Settings, upload logos (folder or individual files), then match each school to its crest.
5. Optionally add stadium photos, helmets, and jerseys the same way.

Each team row in the JSON supports:

name, prestige, classification, region, culture_grade, facilities_grade, booster_support, community, enrollment, stadium_name, rivals, and more.

Top-level league metadata can include:

league_id, state (display name), email_pack, playoff_system

----- TEAM CUSTOMIZATION: MAKE IT YOURS -----

FND is built so your dynasty looks and feels like your league — not a generic template.

LOGOS

Connect schools to logos through a streamlined matching process:

Upload a folder of PNG, JPG, or WEBP images (up to 200 files per batch).
The game suggests matches based on filenames and school names.
You confirm or correct each assignment in Settings.
Logos appear on team pages, schedules, game previews, player cards, and throughout the UI.

Name your files clearly (e.g. "Hurricane_Hurricanes.png") and matching is fast.
Built-in fictional leagues also ship with default crests in data/logos/.

STADIUM PICTURES

Import custom stadium photos per school:

Upload from Team Info while viewing any school.
Supported formats: PNG, JPG, WEBP.
Stored with your account (like logos).
Shown on Team Info and in pregame presentation.

Optional stadium_name in your team JSON sets the display label (e.g. "Eagle Field · Eastview, WV").

HELMETS & JERSEYS

Import helmet and jersey image files per team:

Helmets — one image per school, matched by team name.
Jerseys — home, away, and alternate slots per school.
Same upload-and-match workflow as logos.
Stored in your save bundle for browser play.

These are visual identity layers. They do not change sim outcomes — but they transform how invested you feel walking into Friday night.

RIVALS

Each team can list named rivals (exact team names from the league file). Rivals surface on Team Info and feed into the narrative feel of your season. Build the matchups that matter in your world.

TEAM PROFILE: WHAT DEFINES A PROGRAM

Every school in FND is built from a profile — a set of attributes that determine what kind of program it is, what area it represents, and what kind of player comes up through the pipeline. This is not flavor text. These fields touch roster size, development, recruiting, funding, and the mental makeup of your athletes.

ENROLLMENT

Enrollment is always a massive conversation in real high school sports — and in FND it matters.

Enrollment helps determine:

Classification (when not set manually)

Base roster size

Typical enrollment bands:

1A: under ~250 students → base roster ~30

2A: ~250–500 → base roster ~35

3A: ~500–1,000 → base roster ~45

4A: ~1,000–1,800 → base roster ~55

5A: ~1,800–2,800 → base roster ~70

6A: ~2,800+ → base roster ~85

Final roster size is adjusted by culture grade, community type, and enrollment modifiers — typically landing in the 40–80 player range. Bigger schools with strong football culture can push toward the top of that band. Small rural schools with great culture still field competitive numbers because kids show up when football matters in the town.

CULTURE GRADE (1–10)

Culture is the standard in your building — discipline, buy-in, work ethic, and the football mentality your community expects.

Culture grade affects:

- Roster turnout — strong culture means more kids come out for football
- Player mental makeup — influences traits like effort, discipline, coachability, confidence, and composure in players coming up through your program (including incoming freshmen from the middle school pipeline)
- Program stability — feeds recruiting stability alongside facilities
- Long-term pillar progression — culture is one of three program pillars you invest in and maintain across seasons

A Culture 9 rural school behaves differently than a Culture 5 suburban school even at the same enrollment. The kids play harder. They buy in. Development curves reward that over four years.

FACILITIES GRADE (1–10)

Facilities represent your weight room, training environment, field, and recovery infrastructure.

Facilities grade affects:

- Player development speed — higher facilities mean faster offseason and in-season attribute growth (the development engine scales gains by your facilities grade)
- Growth rate on incoming players — better facilities help young athletes develop physical tools as they move up from middle school / eighth grade into the high school program
- Program stability — pairs with culture for recruiting consistency
- Pillar progression — facilities is a core investment track in the offseason

Facilities 3 blue-collar towns and Facilities 9 affluent suburbs are playing different long games. The coach who inherits weak facilities and raises them over a decade is building a dynasty foundation, not just a number on a screen.

BOOSTER GRADE (1–10)

Booster support represents your community's financial backing — the parents, alumni, and local businesses who fund the program.

Booster grade affects:

- Annual program funding — each season you receive income based on booster

support, win total, and your coach's Community Outreach skill. Strong boosters with a winning season can approach ~\$100,000 in annual income; weak support may land closer to ~\$20,000.

Equipment purchases — funding buys sleds, chutes, nets, recovery gear, and technology from the program equipment catalog. Real attribute bonuses.

Pillar progression — boosters is the third program pillar alongside culture and facilities

Boosters do not replace winning. They amplify it. A 10-win season with Booster 9 and high outreach fills your equipment room. A losing season with Booster 3 forces hard choices about what to buy and what to defer.

COMMUNITY TYPE

Community type is permanent for a school. It defines the character of the town and the talent pipeline that feeds your program. Your long-term development goals need to match your community — fighting your geography is one of the hardest paths in the game.

Six community types, each with ratings (1–10) for talent pool, facilities, culture, stability, and exposure:

RURAL

Talent pool: 4 | Culture: 9 | Stability: 8 | Exposure: 3

Pipeline: RB, LB, OL, TE

Profile: Fewer skill players, elite toughness and culture. Win with development and physical football.

URBAN

Talent pool: 8 | Culture: 5 | Stability: 5 | Exposure: 7

Pipeline: WR, CB, S, QB

Profile: Athletes everywhere. Speed and skill on the perimeter.

SUBURBAN

Talent pool: 7 | Culture: 7 | Stability: 8 | Exposure: 6

Pipeline: QB, WR, LB

Profile: Balanced — the default "well-rounded program" experience.

AFFLUENT

Talent pool: 6 | Facilities: 9 | Exposure: 8

Pipeline: QB, WR, K, P

Profile: Resources outpace raw talent. Facilities and exposure are strengths.

BLUE-COLLAR

Talent pool: 7 | Facilities: 3 | Culture: 9

Pipeline: OL, DL, TE, LB

Profile: Trench town. Great culture, weak facilities. Linemen and linebackers run deep. Invest in facilities to unlock the ceiling.

FOOTBALL FACTORY

Talent pool: 9 | Facilities: 9 | Culture: 10 | Exposure: 10

Pipeline: Every position

Profile: The nightmare on your schedule. Top-tier players every year. These programs are built to win now and reload.

Community type does not change during a dynasty. If you take a rural job, you are building a rural dynasty — lean into the pipeline, max culture, develop linemen and linebackers, and win with seniors who have been in your system. If you land at a Football Factory, the expectation is immediate.

PRESTIGE (1–15)

Prestige is your program's reputation — earned through Team Points accumulated across seasons. Championships, playoff runs, win totals, and elite players move the needle. Prestige feeds recruiting: better reputation attracts higher-potential freshmen.

New saves can start teams at different prestige levels. Building from Prestige 5 to Prestige 12 is one of the most satisfying arcs in the game.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER: BUILDING A WORLD YOU WANT TO LIVE IN

STEP 1 — DEFINE THE LEAGUE

Choose team count (100–150, even number). Split into classes and regions.

Pick a playoff_system that matches how your state runs postseason football.

STEP 2 — BUILD THE JSON

Set each school's enrollment, classification, region, community type, and pillar grades. Name rivals. Set stadium names. Tune prestige for storylines (a sleeping giant at Prestige 6, a juggernaut at Prestige 13).

STEP 3 — CUSTOMIZE THE LOOK

Upload logos, stadiums, helmets, and jerseys. Match every school. The visual

layer makes the sim feel like your Friday night.

STEP 4 — PICK YOUR JOB

Choose a school that fits the story you want to tell:

Developer at a Blue-collar 3A program?

Win-now coach at a Football Factory?

Homecoming hero returning to a Rural 2A school?

STEP 5 — MATCH STRATEGY TO PROFILE

Rural + low facilities → invest in pillars, run the pipeline, develop seniors

Urban + high talent → recruit and scheme, win with speed

Affluent + high facilities → development machine, balanced attack

Football Factory → championships are the expectation, not the dream

CLOSING: YOUR WORLD, YOUR DYNASTY

Friday Night Dynasty 2026 is not just a sim with a default roster of fake teams. It is a platform for building the high school football world you care about — fictional or real, small-town or big-city, rebuild or reload.

The league file is your foundation.

Customization makes it yours.

The team profile is the physics of your program.

Get those three right and every offseason decision, every cross-region pick, every freshman class, and every Friday night feels like it belongs to a world you created.

That's the first deep dive. More coming — playbooks, program building, and the coach's path through the season.

Welcome to your dynasty.